

A show of strength

Prussian troops parade in the Champs Elysées in Paris in January 1871 after their takeover of the city during the Franco-Prussian War. Such displays showed off military strength, and helped build nationalistic pride.

Another politician who understood the power of the desire for national unity was the Prussian statesman Otto von Bismarck (see below). At the time of the 1848 revolutions, Germany was a loose confederation of states, of which the most powerful was Prussia. Bismarck's primary objective was to secure the supremacy of Prussia in Central Europe, but by encouraging the other German states to unify under Prussia, he was also the architect of the German nation.

The process began in 1864, when Prussia joined forces with Austria to annex the duchies of Schleswig and Holstein from Denmark. Two years later Bismarck was ready to deal with Austria, Prussia's chief rival for dominance in Germany. Allied with Italy and several smaller German states, Prussia defeated Austria—who counted the German states of Saxony and Bavaria among their allies—at the Battle of Königgrätz. Final unity came when the southern principalities of Germany joined Prussia in its war against France in 1870. A German victory led to the proclamation of a unified German Empire in 1871. Bismarck was appointed chancellor.

National identities

The principle that nations share a unique, common identity based on a common culture and history was well established by the late 19th century.

CHANCELLOR OF GERMANY (1815–98)

OTTO VON BISMARCK

Otto von Bismarck became prime minister of Prussia in 1862. His ambition was to unite Germany under Prussian leadership—a result he believed could only be achieved by force. Victory in the Franco-Prussian War (1870–71) persuaded the other German states to join together to form an empire. He became the first chancellor of the unified Germany. Although conservative, Bismarck introduced some social reforms in an attempt to reduce the appeal of socialism.



“It is not by means of speeches and majority resolutions that the great issues of the day will be decided—that was the great mistake of 1848 and 1849—but by blood and iron.”

OTTO VON BISMARCK, SEPTEMBER 30, 1862



National languages became paramount, often at the expense of regional dialects. During the struggle to unify Italy, for example, the Italian dialect spoken in Tuscany was chosen, and energetically promoted by writers such as Alessandro Manzoni, who revised and republished his great patriotic novel, *The Betrothed*, in this new national language. Symbols of national identity, such as music and literature, flourished. Sports was a focus of national pride. Military campaigns cemented a growing patriotic fervor with symbolic state emblems and flags. National Days were created, education systems enforced a standard curriculum, and fanfares, marches, and national anthems became prolific across Europe.

In some areas, a particular national identity was enforced by the state in an attempt to suppress or maintain control over other ethnic groups. In Hungary, where the ethnic Hungarians (Magyars) were outnumbered by non-Magyar minorities, the government enforced Magyar as the only legitimate language of administration—a policy known as

National identity

National symbols and rituals such as the flag and Pledge of Allegiance, shown in this US school (c. 1900), could help to forge the identity of a young nation such as the US, which was largely made of immigrants.

“Magyarization.” Anyone who opposed this policy was liable to be charged with “incitement to national hatred.” In 1900, the Russian czar proclaimed Russian the state language of Finland in an attempt to suppress Finnish national identity—the “Russification of Finland.”

Militarism

As liberal nationalism, which had focused on civil rights and a constitution, gave way to imperialist nationalism, based on national pride and expansion, a strong army became essential. Until Napoleon, armies were essentially professional forces whose manpower was drawn from the less socially and economically useful elements of the population. The old idea of loyalty to the king was replaced in the Napoleonic armies (see p.307) with loyalty based upon national patriotism fired by the idea of social revolution. This made it possible for Napoleon to raise the type of mass armies that came to characterize the national armies of the 19th and 20th centuries. The entire population was expected to contribute to the war, and conscription was gradually introduced across Europe. Consequently, armies began to expand to record size.

Mass armies required large supplies of arms. The Industrial Revolution (see pp.292–95) enabled mass production, and advances in technology changed warfare. The Russo-Turkish War of 1877–78 was the first war in which modern repeating rifles were uniformly used, increasing the accuracy of fire, and breech-loading cannon, which loaded from the rear for safety and efficiency, replaced front-loading cannon. By the outbreak of the Russo-Japanese War (1904–05), the use of indirect heavy artillery fire was standard practice. The result was that the armies of the early 20th century had an unprecedented killing capacity.

Nationalism and a desire for independence dominated events in Europe in the years leading up to World War I.

EUROPEAN NATION-STATES

In the years preceding World War I, nationalism in many countries had turned **intolerant, imperialist, and expansionist**. Colonial acquisitions were greeted with enthusiasm and there was a growing sense that nations were in competition with each other. Italians, Serbs, Romanians, Greeks, and Bulgarians dreamed of extending their national borders to include their people who were living outside of their nation-state. This **expansionist nationalism** pitted the nation-states against each other. In 1912, a coalition of Bulgaria, Serbia, Montenegro, and Greece invaded, occupied, and partitioned the Ottoman Empire's European provinces. Disagreement over the spoils led to the **Second Balkan War** (1913) in which Greece and Serbia gained large territories.

INDEPENDENCE

The Russification of Finland in the late 19th century caused such resentment among the Finns that on the

FINNISH DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE

outbreak of the Russian Revolution **376–77** >> **Finland declared itself independent.** A war of independence and civil war was fought in 1918, and Finland officially became a republic in 1919.

Poland had disappeared from the map in 1785, partitioned between Russia, Prussia, and Austria. In 1915, the Germans expelled the Russians from Poland and promised Poland independence. However, the Poles joined the Allies in World War I and their pleas for **freedom** were finally answered in **Versailles** in 1919 when an independent republic was recognized **375** >>.

Similarly, Ireland had also been fighting to shake off alien rule. In 1916, the Easter Rising was crushed by the British **436** >>. In 1921, however, the British signed a treaty with the Irish majority party Sinn Féin to bring about Irish Independence, except for the six northern counties, and in 1922 the Irish Free State came into being.



THE REPUBLIC OF IRELAND'S FLAG

WORLD WAR I

By the early 20th century, **nation-states** replaced small principalities in Europe. In Africa and the East, Europeans were continuing to annex territories for reasons of national pride and **economic advantage** **350–53** >>. These were also joined by a new generation of powers, whose interests were largely economic. Foremost among them were the US and Japan. But nationalism had within it the seeds of destruction. Rivalries between the powers intensified and their ambitions came into conflict. The result was to be **World War I** **372–75** >>.